

Constructive communication at the table

Day 2 · Session 4 | Both sectors | Shared resource

Everything on this sheet is useful whichever approach you are using, including a firmly positional one. Listening well and asking a genuine question do not require you to move your position.

Effective Listening — What to Practise

Full attention — not drafting your next response while the other person is still speaking

Paraphrasing — reflecting back what you heard, in your own words, before you respond

Checking, not assuming — "Have I understood that correctly?" rather than proceeding on a guess

Listening for interests — listening past the stated position for the concern underneath it

Tolerating silence — not rushing to fill a pause; the other side may still be forming the real point

Paraphrasing — DOs and DON'Ts

Do	Don't
Paraphrase before you respond substantively, every time	Paraphrase and then pivot into your counter-argument
Use the other person's own words where you can	Paraphrase so briefly it reads as dismissive ("noted")
Ask a genuine clarifying question if a gap shows up	Interrupt to paraphrase mid-sentence
Notice what was not said, as well as what was	Assume a nod means agreement — check it out loud

The Language of Positional and Needs-Based Negotiation

Positional language	Needs-based language
"Our position is..." / "We demand..."	"What we actually need is..."
"That is non-negotiable."	"Help me understand why that matters to you."
"Take it or leave it."	"What would it take for both of us to..."
A conclusion — invites only agreement or refusal	A genuine question — invites information

Using needs-based language is not the same as adopting a needs-based strategy, and it is not the same as conceding anything. You can hold a firm, mandated position and still choose your words carefully.

Cues That You Are Hearing a Position, Not a Need

A specific number or demand arrives before any explanation of why

Absolute words: always, never, must, non-negotiable

No willingness to explain the reasoning, even when asked warmly

The same sentence repeated with more force rather than more detail

Defensiveness when the demand is questioned, instead of elaboration

A refusal to engage with any "what if" or hypothetical at all

None of these, on its own, proves someone is being purely positional. Two or three together is your signal to stop responding to the position and start asking an open question instead.

Reframing Practice — While Maintaining Your Mandate

For each statement, write one genuine, open question that could uncover the real need behind it. This is not about softening the statement and not about giving ground — a good reframe uncovers information; it does not move your position.

Positional statement	Your open, non-conceding reframe
"We want the weekend rota changed back — full stop."	
"The training budget stays with the department. Not up for discussion."	
"Nobody is moving offices until the parking allocation is sorted out."	
"We are not attending another meeting that gets rescheduled the day before."	
"The allocation rule stands as it is. There is nothing to talk about."	

Weak and Strong Reframes — Quick Reference

Positional statement	Weak reframe (still a challenge)	Strong reframe (genuine question)
"Nobody moves offices until parking is sorted."	"Why is parking so important?"	"What would have to be true about parking for the move to work?"
"The rota goes back to how it was."	"Why can you not work the new rota?"	"What did the old rota make possible that the new one does not?"
"That budget is not up for discussion."	"Why will you not discuss it?"	"What is that budget protecting that a discussion might put at risk?"

Check your own reframes above against this pattern: does the question contain a hidden suggestion that the other side is wrong? If so, it is still a challenge, not a reframe.

One Move: Listen, Paraphrase, Reframe, Wait

- 1. Listen — let the whole position land before you respond**
- 2. Paraphrase — say it back, and earn the right to ask your question**
- 3. Reframe — ask the open question; this commits you to nothing of your own**
- 4. Wait — stop talking; the honest answer rarely arrives in the first three seconds**

Keep this worksheet. Wednesday's Job Grading and Extracting Needs role-plays build on these listening and questioning skills.